



The opening shots of war between the British troops (in red) and the American colonial militia (in the foreground) on Lexington Common in Massachusetts, by English artist William Barnes Wollen (1857–1936).

THE ANGRY RECEPTION GIVEN TO LEGISLATION and discontent over the issue of “**taxation without representation**” in the 13 American colonies had begun to worry British officials and they feared an armed rebellion. On April 18, General Thomas Gage (1721–87), who was also Governor of Massachusetts, sent British soldiers (known as “redcoats”) to seize the guns and ammunition being stored by the colonists in the town of

Concord, just outside of Boston. Aware that the British might execute such a plan, the colonists had set up a system of alerts should any event come to pass. Once news was received of the planned raid on Concord, Boston silversmith and engraver **Paul Revere** (1735–1818) set off from the city that night to warn fellow

organizers that British troops were on the march. Minutemen (militia who were ready to fight “at a minute’s notice”) grabbed their guns and waited for the arrival of the redcoats.

On the morning of April 19 the “shot heard around the world” was fired and battle ensued between colonists and British troops in **Lexington** and nearby **Concord**. The **American Revolutionary War** had begun.

Fighting continued through the summer. Colonial forces, under the command of **General George Washington** (1732–99) captured key points near **Lake Champlain**, but the British defeated them at the **Battle of Bunker Hill** on June 17, despite losing half their troops in the process.

Within the colonies the war was divisive. Not all colonists were willing to fight against Britain and soon people were divided into **patriots** and **loyalists**. Some 20 percent of the population of the 13 colonies were estimated to have supported the Crown. Within this number were **American Indians** and **slaves**. In the case of the former, some tribes sided with the British because they were valued trading partners. Many also thought their interests, such



Continental soldier’s hat

This style of tricorne was worn by American colonists fighting for the Continental army.

as territorial boundaries, stood a better chance of being protected by Britain. For slaves, the incentive to side with the British Crown was the possibility of **emancipation**—they had been told they would be freed if they fought for the king. Some residents, such as the **Quakers**, opposed warfare. Many others simply wanted to avoid participation in either side of the conflict.

Halfway around the world, British East India Company troops were embroiled in the domestic troubles of the Marathas (see 1758). The **First Anglo-Maratha War** (1775–82) was the result of the East India Company’s intervention into the Maratha Confederacy, a union of five clans that came to power after the collapse of the kingdom of Maharashtra. This war left many issues unresolved and tensions would rise again between the British and Marathas, leading to two further wars (see 1803).

In Britain, Scottish inventor and engineer **James Watt** (1736–1819) had struck up a business partnership with Matthew Boulton (1728–1809),

who owned an engineering works. Watt had improved the **Newcomen steam engine**, which had been around since the turn of the century. He developed a separate condensing chamber for the engine, which made it lose less steam and be more efficient. In partnership with Boulton, Watt began to manufacture these engines in 1775. At this point steam engines were used mostly to pump water from mines, but Watt saw more potential uses for steam and continued working on engines for the rest of his life. His inventions allowed later engineers to revolutionize transportation and he thereby effectively laid the foundations of modern industry.



THOMAS PAINE

Thomas Paine (1737–1809) was born in Norfolk, England. He emigrated to America and advocated independence. He returned to England and wrote *Rights of Man*, defending the French Revolution, which cemented his reputation as a radical propagandist.

Steam power

James Watt’s work on steam engines allowed for the development of steam-powered trains.

